

“God has brought us
to where we are...”

OLIVER CROMWELL, ADDRESSING THE ARMY COUNCIL. 1654

and lost his right to dissolve Parliament. Rumors of his complicity in an Irish rebellion against Protestant English rule increased the tension. When news reached Charles that Parliament intended to impeach (charge with improper conduct) his Catholic queen, Henrietta Maria, he took drastic action. In January 1642, he entered the House of Commons with an armed force, intending to arrest five leading radical MPs for high treason. Forewarned, they took refuge in the City of London, which considered Charles's actions an outrage. Fearing for his safety, Charles went north to raise an army, while his queen went abroad to raise funds to pay for it.

A full-length bronze statue of Oliver Cromwell, standing in ornate 17th-century armor. He is holding a sword in his right hand and has his left hand on his hip. The statue is set against a plain white background.

The reign of Charles I was characterized by religious conflict. Combining charm with stubbornness, his absolutist tendencies, (see p.279) put him on a collision course with Parliament.

While the king commanded the loyalty of Wales, the west, and the north, Parliament controlled London, the east, and the south. The initial battles were inconclusive—a draw at Edgehill was followed by victories for the royalists, or Cavaliers, at Landsdown and Adwalton Moor in 1643, and for the Parliamentarians, or Roundheads, at Turnham Green and Newbury. Numerical supremacy and Scottish involvement led to Roundhead victories at Marston Moor in 1644, and at Naseby and Langport in 1645.

The conspirators intend to seize the Tower of London and secure the forts, while Royalist forces from Oxford meet up with the advancing Cornish forces under Sir Ralph Hopton.



With suspicions aroused, the Commons orders the detention of the King's emissary Alexander Hampden on May 22. On May 31, they order the arrest of the suspected conspirators on the evidence of a spy.

When the pope refused **Henry VIII** a divorce from his first wife, Henry rejected the pope's authority and declared himself head of the Church of England in 1534. **The Reformation << 256–59** that followed was consolidated during **Elizabeth I's << 260–61** reign by legislation making **Protestantism** England's national religion. Since she was childless, she was succeeded in 1603 by her Stuart cousin, **James VI of Scotland**.

James's belief in the **Divine Right of Kings** (that the king was god's representative on Earth with unlimited authority) antagonized Parliament. He quarreled with them over taxes and religious laws.

Relations between James's son **Charles I** and Parliament disintegrated further, exacerbated by his anti-Puritan **CC 259** policies. By 1629, he had dismissed Parliament three times, governing alone during the "Eleven Years Tyranny" (1629–40). He enforced royal authority through the Courts instead and raised money by selling titles.